🧠 Substance Use & Abuse: Reading

Health · Unit 3 · Level 3 (closer to the class work) · goes with the Substance Use and Abuse module (Vocabulary, Progression, Stages of Change, Risk/Protective Factors, Fentanyl, CRAAP, Policy)

Name: _____

Substances, the Brain and Making Safe Choices

A substance is anything that changes your mood or mind. Alcohol, nicotine, cannabis, opioids and stimulants are all substances. The human brain keeps developing until about age 25, and the prefrontal cortex, which controls decisions, planning and self-control, finishes last. Substance use during the teen years can change how the developing brain works and raises the risk of addiction.

Use often follows a progression: experimentation (trying it), mild use, moderate use (when use starts causing problems) and severe use (when it is hard to stop and it takes over parts of life). People who decide to change often move through the stages of change: pre-contemplation, contemplation, preparation, action and maintenance. Relapse, going back to using, is common and does not mean failure; a person can start the stages again.

Risk factors make harm more likely, and protective factors lower it. They can be biological (family history, age of first use), psychological (stress, trauma, coping skills) and social (friends who use, caring adults, school activities). Alcohol causes about 178,000 deaths in the U.S. each year. U.S. overdose deaths fell from 81,313 in 2024 to 69,973 in 2025, and most involve fentanyl.

Fentanyl is a very strong opioid. It is often pressed into fake pills that look like real medicine, and a tiny amount can cause an overdose. Signs of an opioid overdose include not waking up, slow or no breathing and blue or gray lips. Call 911, give naloxone (Narcan) if it is available, and stay with the person. Washington's Good Samaritan law protects people who call for help during an overdose from being charged for small amounts of drugs.

Information about drugs online is not always true. The CRAAP test checks a source: Currency (is it recent?), Relevance (does it answer my question?), Authority (who wrote it?), Accuracy (is it supported by evidence?) and Purpose (why was it made?). Words matter too: person-first language, such as “a person with a substance use disorder,” reduces shame and helps people ask for help.

Check your reading

1. Why are teens at higher risk from substance use than adults?

2. What are three signs of an opioid overdose, and what should you do?

3. Why does the Good Samaritan law exist?